“three glass jars with sand and pebbles ‘soaked in the blood of martyrs’.’[4] On the other hand, Bhagat Singh did very likely go to Nankana Sahib Gurdwara, Sheikhpura District, in March 1921 after scores of pilgrims were murdered in cold blood by government appointed priests for demanding democratic control of their places of worship when he was just 14-years old. Two months later the National College was to be established in Lahore in May 1921 at which Bhagat Singh would enrol. What is not in doubt is that by the time he had come into his own, Bhagat Singh wanted to become like his uncle, Ajit Singh, ‘and to give hell to the British’.[5]

Unsurprisingly, by 1926, when just nineteen, Bhagat Singh was already falling under the watchful eye of the authorities. His letters were being intercepted by the police. He realized this when he noticed how ‘all the letters addressed to me were stamped and then stamped again’ as they were ‘cut exactly at the same place’ and that ‘this of course did arouse suspicion in my mind’.[6] When on 17 November 1926 Bhagat Singh asked whether his letters were being detained ‘under orders of the Punjab Government’ and ‘are there any letters that were intercepted and never delivered to me?’,[7] he was initially met with no reply. Bhagat Singh was among thirty-five persons being shadowed by the CID in Punjab and whose mail was being intercepted in 1926. He was listed under Serial No. 16, and his report read, ‘Bhagat Singh, originally of Jullunder District, now of Khawasarian, P.S. Mopzang, Lahore’. When he wrote again a week later protesting how, ‘naturally, I was very anxious to know what led the Punjab Government to issue such orders’, making it clear that ‘as an honest person I have a right to enquire such a question . . .’,[8] it was the chief secretary of Punjab himself who confirmed the next day on 27 November 1926 that no less a person than the governor of Punjab had ordered the interception of Bhagat Singh’s letters. Within six months, Bhagat Singh was wrongly arrested. This was on 29 May 1927 in relation to the Dussehra bomb blast, which had occurred in Lahore in October 1926.

What happened was that Bhagat Singh was apprehended by the police in Lahore when blissfully passing through a garden and then detained in a cell by the Railway Police, where he languished for a month. This was on